the assassins had targeted some of the onlookers to pre-empt eyewitness accounts. And then they had fled.

Investigations had revealed that the killers had hijacked a Maruti van, in which an officer of a private company and his mother were travelling near Villupuram a day later. The attackers then dropped the occupants on the side of the road and took off in the van. The local police traced the owner of the Maruti van, Thomas Charles, and brought him to Malligai. When Raju and Kanth spoke to Charles, he said there were six hijackers. Four of them, in the age group of twenty to twenty-five years, got out of the white Ambassador and forcibly stopped his van. In addition to sophisticated arms, they were carrying walkie-talkies. They threatened him with consequences if he or his family members talked to anyone about the incident. Charles gave Kanth and Raju a general description of the attackers. But there was nothing more he could help with. He said he could not understand the dialect the men used while communicating with each other. It sounded like Sinhala-Tamil.

A breakthrough happened amid the confusion, purely by chance. A routine police check near the Vedaranyam beach, also known for smuggling activities, involved a young man speeding on a motorcycle. The state was already on alert. When the police asked the rider to get off, he said he was in a hurry. From his accent, the police felt he sounded like a Sri Lankan Tamil. That was enough reason for the police to take him in. His interrogation threw up dramatic results. The young man turned out to be Shankar Koneswaran from Jaffna, who had been living there as a ‘Sri Lankan refugee’. In the aftermath of Rajiv Gandhi’s assassination, any link with Jaffna was treated as ‘extra-sensitive’. The Vedaranyam police immediately informed the SIT in Madras about the suspect through a fax message:

> The Tamil Nadu Police has picked up an LTTE militant Shankar Koneswaran alias Ruso in Thanjavur and found telephone